

Sanjana, 13, got the best of everything. His death that terrible night shattered Kalpana so much that she stopped socialising for a year. Somewhere she feared that she would break down if she met people. So she immersed herself in yoga and spirituality which has given her immense strength. She began valuing her family and friends more, but doesn't think it would have been possible without meditation. A prayer meeting, Bhagvad, was recently organised for Pankaj. Only then she could accept the reality that he had gone.

Her life is now dedicated to raising her children and fulfilling her husband's dreams. So she runs his business as passionately as he used to and pursues her own interest in art through Tao. Her son Sarjan does assist her with the business even while studying at the London School of Economics. But she can't wait for the time when he'll be back and they will both take their company to greater heights. Her daughter, who's in school, is closer to her as she lives in Mumbai. Kalpana does not wish to carry her baggage of sorrow to every place she goes. "I have lived in Mumbai all my life, been an active and confident girl in college and yet feel devastated. I wouldn't want any other woman to go through this," she says. She is visiting more pilgrim spots for peace. While she came back from Varanasi just this month, she will again head to Rishikesh on November 26. "I pray for world peace and riddance from terrorism," she says. **by Mitali Patel**

TO HELL AND BACK

SIR GULAM NOON, 73

WHAT HAPPENED: Noon was rescued from the Taj on 26/11

Young lady," the bespectacled businessman smiled at the receptionist at the Taj. "why are you demoting me?" For close to three decades, the opulent suites on the sixth floor of the Taj had always hosted Indian-born British businessman Sir Gulam Noon. But on November 21, Noon, known as the 'Curry King', had to settle for a room on the third floor of his favourite hotel. Yet the downgrade would conspire to keep Noon and five business partners alive in the war zone that the Taj turned into five days later. At 9.26 pm on 26/11, as Noon exited the elevator towards his suite, his butler rushed him in. "Sir! Run." The crackle of gunfire had begun echoing in the hotel lobby. Noon and his five business associates barricaded themselves inside the sea-facing suite in the north wing, shifting furniture to block the doors and plugging the gaps with wet towels. They shut off the lights. The TV relayed the frightening images of a city under assault. Close to midnight, the century-old heritage building reverberated with an earthquake-like massive

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“Mumbaikars are like Londoners. If you are deterred, the terrorists win and I'm not going to let that happen.”

GULAM NOON

explosion, and tongues of flames leapt out of the hotel's south wing. There was a frantic hammering on the door. He froze when he looked through the peephole—there were two armed youths holding AK-47s.

Noon had survived many several close calls, including a terrifying air crash in Iraq in 1974. But this time, it was anybody's guess whether the entrepreneur who started out from Mumbai's Crawford Market would be as lucky. The situation grew gloomier when they realised that the terrorists were looking for American and British nationals. Here was a roomful of potential hostages with terrorists outside. While his companions frenetically texted their families, Noon was pensive. He rapidly scribbled 10 points for his wife, children and grandchildren telling them what to do in case he died. He wrapped the note in a shower cap to protect it from the blood in case his body was found and tucked it into his hip pocket. The 10 most terrifying hours of his life ended the next morning when a fire brigade ladder appeared and swiftly evacuated them. The first thing Noon did was to walk across the road and cast his note into the Arabian Sea. He has never told anyone about its contents.

Two months later, he was back in a suite at the Taj. "Londoners are like Mumbaikars you know," he says. "If you are deterred, the terrorists win and I am not about to let that happen."

by Sandeep Unnithan